CARDAMOMPULSE · A DATA ALMANAC

The Cardamom Almanac

Eleven years. 5,440 auctions. One small green pod whose price has swung 9.4× fold. Here is what the numbers say about when to sell, when to plant, and where the market really gets made.

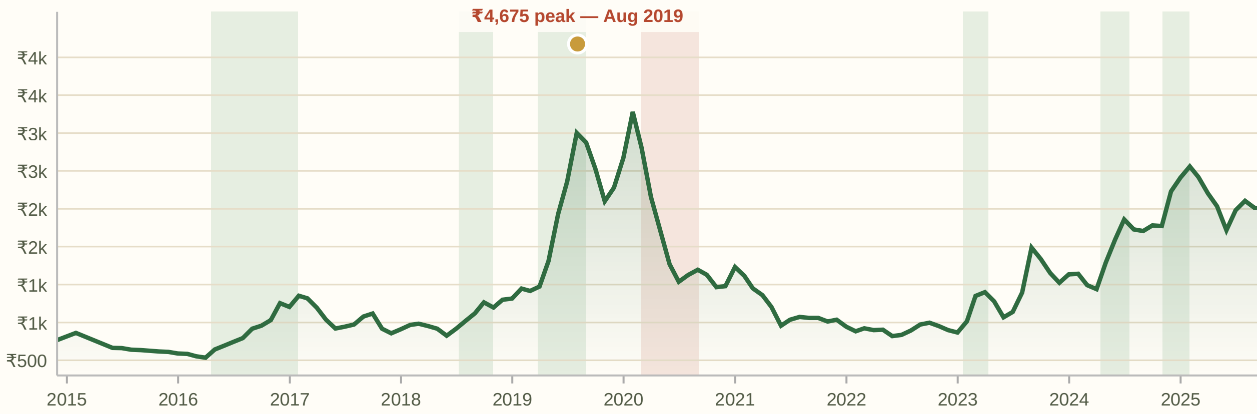
Coverage 2014-11-07 to 2026-02-06 · 3,028 trading days · 5,440 individual auctions

₹495	₹4,675	9.4×	+256%
floor (2016-03)	peak (2019-08)	peak-to-trough swing	biggest 6-month rally

01

A price with a temper

Few farm commodities move like cardamom. Since 2014 the auction price has travelled from under ₹500 to nearly ₹4,700 a kilo and back again — a roller-coaster driven by monsoons, floods and the slow churn of planting cycles.



Monthly average auction price, Nov 2014 – Feb 2026. Green bands = bull runs >20%; red bands = bear runs >20%.

₹4,675	-67%	+256%	₹2,505
2019 flood peak	biggest 6-month crash	biggest 6-month rally	latest print

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Cardamom is a **boom-and-bust crop.** The single biggest fortunes — and ruins — were made by those who read the cycle, not the week. The 2019 flood spike to ₹4,675 was followed by a two-thirds collapse. Plan for the swing; never assume today's price is the new normal.

"The market spends years quietly cheap, then re-prices violently in a single season."

02

What actually moves the price

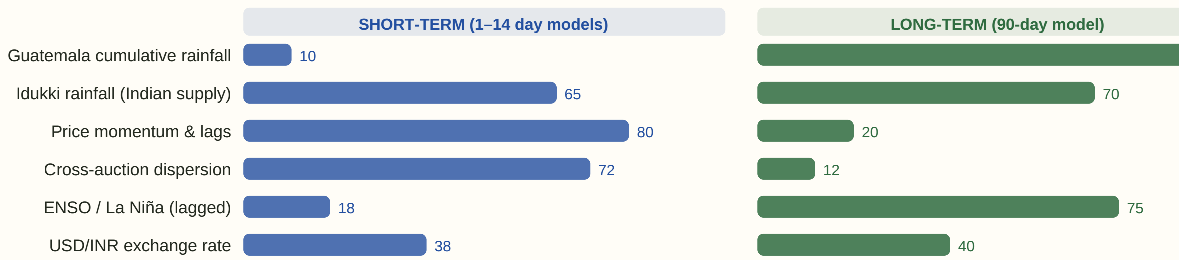
The answer depends entirely on your time horizon. **Guatemala is the master variable for price levels over months and years** — it produces ~70% of the world's cardamom supply. Indian auction dynamics dominate week-to-week moves. Our forecast models confirm this split precisely.

SHORT-TERM · DAYS TO WEEKS

- Price momentum & moving averages
  1–14 day moves
- Cross-auction price dispersion
  leading signal at 7–14 days
- Idukki rainfall (weekly signal)
  near-term supply shock
- Seasonality / calendar position
  lean vs harvest window
- USD/INR exchange rate
  export demand response

LONG-TERM · MONTHS TO YEARS

- Guatemala cumulative rainfall
  #1 feature in 90-day model; ~70% global supply
- ENSO (El Niño / La Niña, lagged)
  6–12 month lag on Guatemala climate
- Idukki cumulative monsoon (90d)
  Indian supply for the coming season
- Guatemala export volumes
  direct supply signal with 3–6m lag
- Cobweb cycle age & cost ratio
  structural planting cycle position



Bar length = relative predictive power in out-of-sample walk-forward models. Blue = short-horizon (1–14 day); green = long-horizon (90-day).

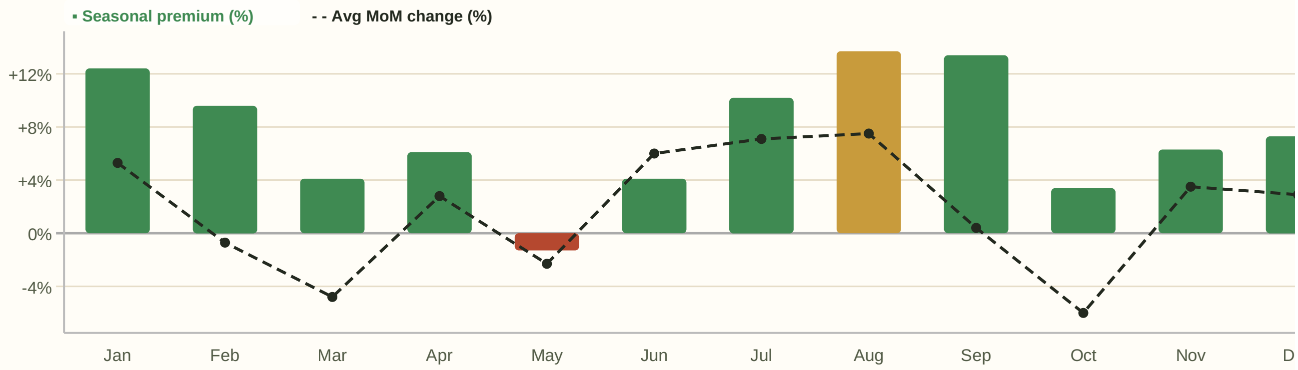
READING THE TWO COLUMNS TOGETHER

The short-term column tells you *when* to sell this season. The long-term column tells you *what price era* you are in. A poor Guatemalan harvest starts a bull market 6–18 months later; an Idukki rain event moves next week's auction. Both matter — on very different clocks.

03

The selling calendar

Strip away the long-term trend and a clear yearly rhythm appears. Some months reliably pay more than others — and one month reliably punishes those who wait.



Bars: average price in each month vs its own 12-month average (seasonal premium). Dashed line: average month-on-month change.

BEST WINDOW TO SELL

Prices sit highest from mid-summer through early autumn — **Jan, Jul, Aug, Sep** all run 10–14% above their yearly average, with **Aug** the single strongest month. Holding stock for this window has historically paid about **15% more** than selling in the weakest month.

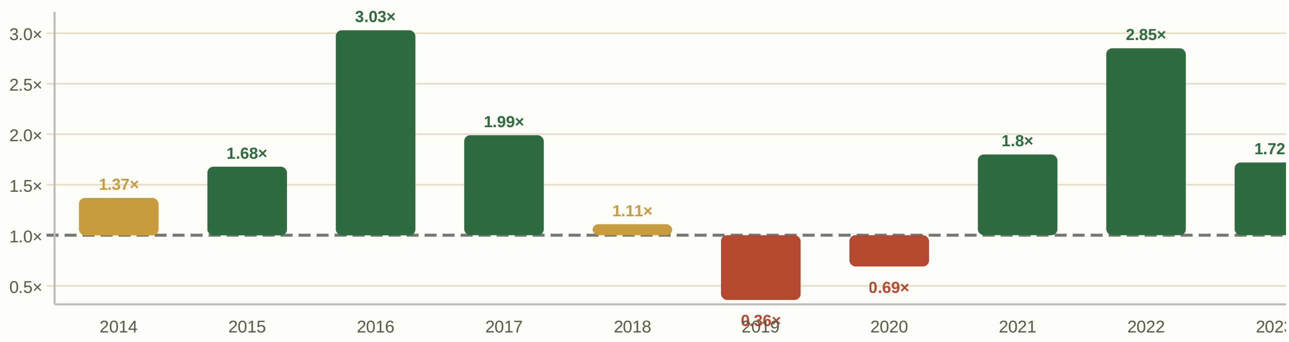
THE TRAP MONTH

Oct shows the steepest average drop of the year (-6.0% in one month) as the harvest floods the market. Spring (around **May**) is the softest patch. Don't drift into the harvest glut holding unsold stock.

04

The planter's paradox

A new cardamom field takes about three years to come into full bearing. So the price that matters isn't today's — it's the one waiting for you at harvest. History is brutally clear about when to put plants in the ground.



For each planting year: the price multiple at harvest (~3 years later). Above 1× = real gain; below = real loss.

THE GOLDEN WINDOW

Planting in **2016**, when prices were just **₹824**, meant harvesting into **₹2,496** — a **3.03× return.** Low prices today mean few new plants going in; tight supply follows at harvest time.

THE WIDOW-MAKER

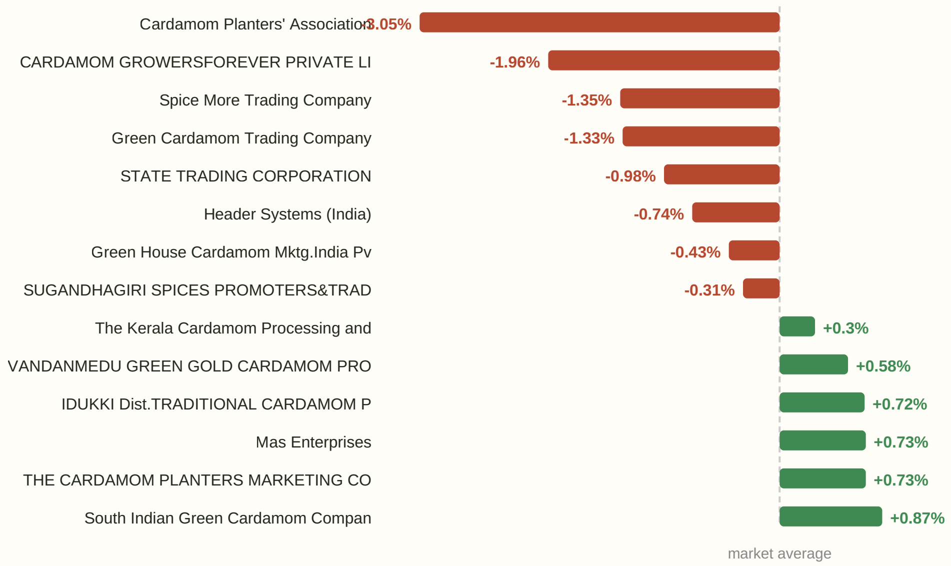
In **2019**, with prices euphoric at **₹2,496**, everyone planted at once. Three years on the price had collapsed to **₹903** — just **0.36×**, a real purchasing-power loss.

"Plant into cheap prices, not into headlines. The crowd that planted at the 2019 peak harvested into a 64% loss."

05

Where you sell is worth money

On any given day two or three auction houses run their own sales. They are not interchangeable — a stubborn pecking order has persisted for years.



Average price achieved by each house relative to the same-day market average. Based on days with ≥2 concurrent auctions.

+0.87%	83%	-3.05%	3.9%
best house premium	days it beats market	worst house discount	top-to-bottom gap

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

The gap between best and worst clearing house is **3.9%** — on a tonne of cardamom that is real money, compounding at every sale. Favour the houses that consistently fetch more. The top-ranked house beats the market on **83%** of days.

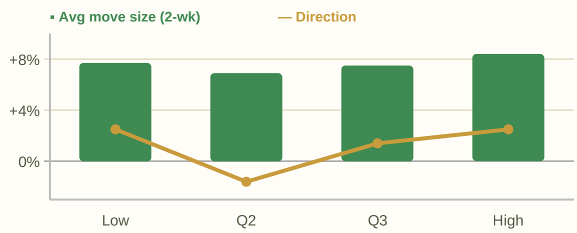
A market on a weekly clock

Each major house owns a weekday — the "daily price" is really a rotating cast.

Mas Enterprises	**Saturday** (44%)	South Indian Green Car	**Tuesday** (42%)
Header Systems (India)	**Tuesday** (41%)	Kerala Cardamom Proces	**Thursday** (47%)
Green House Cardamom M	**Saturday** (41%)	SUGANDHAGIRI SPICES	**Wednesday** (44%)
IDUKKI Traditional Pro	**Monday** (45%)	Cardamom GrowersForeve	**Friday** (42%)

When the houses disagree

Wide inter-auction spread predicts bigger moves ahead — and historically upward.



14-day dispersion quartile vs size & direction of the following 2-week move.

06

The grower's playbook

Seven rules the data backs — one for each major finding in this almanac.

Seven rules from eleven years of data

1. **Guatemala is the macro signal.** Its cumulative 6-month rainfall is the #1 driver of annual price levels. A drought in Alta Verapaz starts a bull market 6–18 months later. Watch USDA Guatemala crop reports alongside the Idukki monsoon.
2. **Respect the cycle.** Cardamom swings 9.4× between peaks and troughs. Today's price is a moment in a multi-year pattern, not a permanent new level.
3. **Watch the rain, not the rumour.** Idukki monsoon data and El Niño/La Niña forecasts (lagged 6–12 months) shape Indian supply more reliably than any market tip.
4. **Sell into strength (Jan–Aug).** The mid-year window pays ~15% over the weakest month. Avoid the Oct harvest glut if you can store safely.
5. **Plant cheap, never hot.** Fields planted in low-price years like 2016 returned 3.03×. Those planted at the 2019 peak returned just 0.36×. The crowd is almost always wrong.
6. **Know your auction house.** A 3.9% premium gap separates the best and worst houses for comparable produce. It compounds at every sale, every season.
7. **Read the disagreement.** When same-day auction prices diverge widely, the next two weeks tend to move more — and historically lean upward. High dispersion is a quiet tell.

About this almanac. Built from the Spices Board of India e-auction record (2014-11-07 – 2026-02-06) plus Open-Meteo weather data, NOAA ENSO indices, and USD/INR rates. Price-driver rankings come from out-of-sample walk-forward forecast models (CardamomPulse v2.2). This is market analysis, not financial advice — cardamom is volatile and past patterns do not guarantee future prices.

11 years | 5,440 auctions | 14 auction houses | CardamomPulse v2.2